

talking about, then things get easier. Open source won't get the desired boost if we do not have the backing of enterprise-led activation. So, if we have some successful case studies with respect to open source, then convincing clients is not a challenge.

Q How has your journey with open source been so far?

It's been extremely good. Our engineers are pretty comfortable in approaching forums, looking for a solution, trying to resolve a problem that has not been resolved before and getting their problems solved. People go for closed source solutions or tried-and-tested solutions if they are not confident about finding a way out of a problem. Our team is pretty good at going to forums to seek solutions, and it tries to find out how to do what others have not done before.

Q What are the pre-requisites that one should have before going for an open source solution?

In general, you have to break the problem into parts. So, even if the specific product that you are attempting to implement is something that you haven't done before, you would like to try and see whether its components or pieces have been already worked on before or not. If the pieces have already been worked on, it is a cakewalk.

But if they haven't been worked on, then you would pick up a couple of pieces that you find slightly challenging or those that slightly deviate from normal coding and try and do a small proof-of-concept (PoC) around it before adopting it as the solution for the complete team or the clients to follow. So, these PoCs are pretty relevant in the sense that they take away a lot of the risks.

As an example, we are currently working with a leading retailer in India to try and automate its warehouse management system. At present, its systems are mostly on paper or Excel spreadsheet – that is how the picking, packing, shipping process is carried out. We are in talks with the firm to try and automate the process. When we proposed the solution, we found a couple of elements that they are not really confident about and which they haven't worked on before. And those are the parts of the solution that were pretty exciting to them. We took a step back and told them that these are parts in the complete solution that we haven't really done before so let us get a proof-of-concept on these points. So, we are currently doing a one-month project rather than a complete one. Once we are done and agreed on what the thresholds and boundaries would be, we will go for the complete solution.

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Q What are the advantages of using open source technology?

Cost is one definite advantage. Apart from that, we see that generally, updates come pretty fast in open source as compared to a company that would be developing a particular product. There's an army of people who support it and keep contributing to it, which makes it pretty easy for any problem or any new idea that comes in to get implemented in the open source project. So, updates, adaptations or innovations come out first in the open source world. Whatever is coming in as a standard solution gets adapted pretty fast but besides that, there are quite a few innovations that come out and we get the first-mover advantage when we roll out innovations that people haven't seen.

Q According to you, what are the disadvantages of using open source technology?

You don't have solutions readily available all the time. At times, the support is limited. And you could get into some tight corners which are difficult to come out of. So, it's

not easy to get a vendor from that corner for support. It would be slightly complicated since you have to work your way into forums, try and get your queries answered, etc. Nobody might have worked on the solution you have in mind so you might need

to work around the problem.

Q Do you get enough talent to work on open source based projects?

The open source projects are getting increasingly exciting. The techies and even those who've just passed out of college are excited about open source and are willing to try their hands at it. Moreover, it's not really tough to motivate people to work with open source.

Q Are these people talented and skilled enough?

Yes. Because the geeks are more excited about working on open source, we get a lot of good talent when getting started on open source projects. Interestingly, they keep themselves updated on what is happening in the world and would know a lot of stuff that our clients may not have heard of. So, it's easy to get people. Also, I believe that the number of people in open source is either equal to or higher than those using proprietary technologies.

Q You are one of the few CTOs to say so. Most people feel that talent is one of their biggest problems...

We are seeing a lot of traction in the Java world today. There are a lot of firms that are working more on Java currently. If we look at Indian e-commerce players, all of